WHAT IS A UROSTOMY?

A urostomy is a surgically created opening – on the abdomen – that allows urine to flow out of the body. A urostomy may be done because of an injury, a birth defect or a disease. Many times, the person's bladder and urethra are surgically removed. When a person has a urostomy, urine is no longer eliminated through the urethra. A urostomy does not have a sphincter muscle, so a person who has a urostomy has no voluntary control over when to urinate. Instead, the person wears a pouch to collect the urine.

THE STOMA

Each person's stoma is unique. Chances are your stoma will look different from another person's stoma. Your stoma will probably be swollen after surgery; it may take several months for the stoma to shrink to a permanent size. The skin around the stoma is called the peristomal skin. There are no nerve endings in the stoma, so the stoma is not painful. The stoma is always red and moist – somewhat like the inside of a person's mouth. The stoma may also bleed easily, especially if it is hit or rubbed. This type of minor, temporary bleeding of the stoma is normal. (If the bleeding continues, or if the discharge [urine] from the stoma is bloody, contact your doctor].

UROSTOMY POUCHES

Urostomy pouches have anti – reflux valves, which prevent urine that is collecting in the pouch from flowing back toward the stoma. Each urostomy pouch has a drain valve at the bottom of the pouch, so that the pouch can be emptied as needed. Generally, it is a good idea to empty your pouch when it is about one-third full. At night time, a length of flexible tubing can be attached to the drain valve on your pouch. This allows the urine to flow into a bedside collector while you sleep. Many people find a bedside collector preferable to getting up during the night and emptying the pouch.

ODOUR

Odour from the urine is a concern many people have about living with a urostomy. Today, urostomy pouches are made with odour barrier film, so odour from the urine is contained inside the pouch. Sometimes certain foods such as asparagus and seafood can cause your urine to have a strong odour. Also some medications can affect the odour of urine.

PREVENTING URINARY TRACT INFECTIONS

People who have urinary diversions can develop urinary tract infections. Some warning signs of a urinary tract infection include:

Dark, cloudy urine
Strong smelling urine
Back pain [where the kidneys are located]
Fever
Loss of appetite.

Lifestyle tips.
Drinking plenty of water each day is the best way to prevent urinary tract infections.
Empty the pouch regularly.
If you notice any signs of urinary infection contact your doctor.

DIET AND FLUIDS

For most people, a urostomy has very little affect on diet. If you have a history of kidney stones, your doctor may suggest changes in your diet, however most people who have urostomies are able to eat whatever they like.

Lifestyle tips

Eat a balanced diet.
Eating beets, carrots, spinach and berries can colour your urine.
Drink plenty of water each day.
Drinking cranberry juice can help to maintain the natural acidity of urine.

BATHING or SHOWERING

With a urostomy, you can shower or bathe just as you did before. Soap and water will not flow into your stoma or hurt your stoma in any way. You must choose to shower or bathe with your pouch on or off – the choice is yours. (Remember though your urostomy will continue to function, urine will continue to flow from your stoma]

SKIN CARE

It is very important for the skin around the stoma to remain healthy and free of irritation. The peristomal skin should look just like the skin elsewhere on your abdomen. Each time you remove your appliance, look carefully at the peristomal skin. If you notice any swelling, redness or rash, you could have irritated skin. Sometimes but not always, irritated skin is painful. If the problem persists for more than two appliance changes contact your stoma nurse.

RETURNING TO WORK AND TRAVELLING

As with any surgery, you will need to allow some recovery time. Recovery from this type of surgery can take from six to eight weeks. You should check with your doctor before returning to work. After your recovery, you should be able to return to work, or travel just about anywhere. Your urostomy should not limit you. Of course it is always a good idea to take your own supplies with you when you travel and always take more than you think you will need.

EXERCISE and SPORTS

A urostomy should not prevent you from exercising or from being physically active. Other than extremely rough contact sports or very heavy lifting, you should be able to enjoy the same type of physical activities you enjoyed before your surgery. People who have urostomies are able to swim, water ski or snow ski, play golf, tennis, volleyball, sail or jog just as well after their surgery as they did before.

SEX and PERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS

Because urostomy surgery is a body altering procedure, many people worry about sex and intimacy and about acceptance by their partner. It is important to remember that supportive personal relationships can be major sources of healing after any type of surgery. It is also important to let your partner know that sexual activity will not hurt you or your stoma. Urostomy surgery affects both partners in a relationship, and it is something to which both partners must adjust – each in his or her, own way. The key, of course, is understanding and communication. For men, urostomy surgery can sometime cause a change in sexual function. It is very important to discuss the surgery openly with your loved one. Also, do not hesitate to discuss this aspect of the surgery with your doctor.

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